EXTENDING THE NETWORK

- The National Rail Plan envisions enhancing India's high-speed rail (HSR) network to connect all important cities
- As part of the National Infrastructure Pipeline, seven HSR corridors have been identified
- The plan is to make them operational between 2031 and 2051 in a phased manner
- For now, the Ministry of Railways has asked the National High Speed Rail Corporation Limited to prepare their detailed project reports



1. Delhi-Chandigarh-Ludhiana-Jalandhar-Amritsar **476 km**
2. Delhi-Lucknow-Varanasi **813 km**
3. Varanasi-Patna-Howrah **752 km**
4. Delhi-Jaipur-Udaipur-Ahmedabad **872 km**
5. Nagpur-Nashik-Mumbai **767 km**
6. Mumbai-Pune-Hyderabad **671 km**
7. Chennai-Bengaluru-Mysuru **464 km**

tion major Airbus is in the final stages of setting up an aircraft manufacturing unit in collaboration with Tata Advanced Systems. Even the Canadian giant Bombardier has a railway car manufacturing and assembly unit at Savli in Vadodara. "Engineering and service industries are coming up on the stretch," says Pathik Patwari, the previous president of the Gujarat Chamber of Commerce and Industry. "We expect Vadodara to emerge as a vibrant aviation and rail cart manufacturing hub. Combined with the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor (DMIC) that passes through the region, development of the logistics manufacturing sector is also on the cards."

URBAN DEVELOPMENT

The DMIC runs almost parallel to the bullet train line, paving the way for planned urban pockets in the green countryside. In fact, urban development seems to be on steroids along the MAHSR's entire 352 km stretch in Gujarat. Only three of the eight stations in the state—Sabarmati, Ahmedabad and Vadodara—are located within a city. The Anand station is located in a village (Uttarsanda), Bharuch and Surat stations are on the outskirts of the two cities, and Bilimora and Vapi stations are greenfield sites. These HSR stations will have a significant impact on their surroundings, referred to as 'station influence areas'.



"WE CAN EXPECT BUSINESS, HIGH-END RETAIL, RESIDENTIAL, TOURISM, HOSPITALITY AND INSTITUTIONAL DEVELOPMENT ALONG THE INFLUENCE AREAS OF ALL 12 STATIONS. NEW SATELLITE CITIES MAY DEVELOP IN GREENFIELD AREAS"

HARPAL DAVE
Additional Chief Town Planner, Gujarat

In October 2022, the GoI signed a technical cooperation agreement with JICA to handhold Indian urban planners for five years to develop these areas that extend up to a radius of two kilometres. Arterial roads are being developed for a further 5-7 kilometres for seamless mobility. Pedestrian streets and public spaces will also come up in a phased manner.

"Development of two station influence areas in Gujarat—Sabarmati and Surat—and two in Maharashtra—Boisar and Thane—are being monitored under this agreement," says Harpal Dave, additional chief town planner, Gujarat. "We will develop the remaining ones on similar lines." Modalities for at least one medical tourism hub and a premier education township are also being worked out. Dave envisions a seamless economic corridor connecting Mumbai, Surat and Ahmedabad, which would require "special urban planning". "We can expect business, high-end retail, residential, tourism, hospitality and institutional development along the influence areas of all 12 stations," he says. "New satellite cities may develop in greenfield areas. This transformation will happen gradually."

As the HSR stations and viaducts are now finally taking shape along the route, apprehensions about the project are giving way to excitement, even though it's still a long way before India's maiden bullet train zips from Ahmedabad to Mumbai. ■